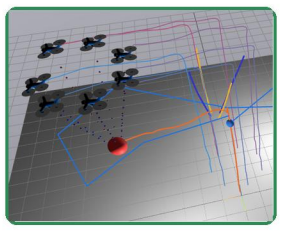
Inherent Cable-Fault Tolerance in Decentralized Cooperative Aerial Transport

When cables snap mid-flight, the remaining drones absorb the fault and keep tracking the payload — with no fault detection, no communication, and no reconfiguration.

No fault detection | No communication | No reconfiguration | 43.6 cm RMSE

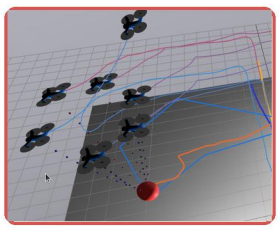
1 Three-stage recovery sequence

01



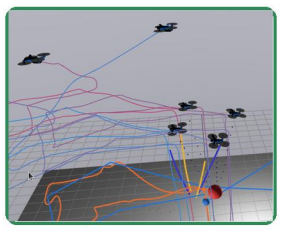
01 Nominal operation
Seven quadrotors carry a cable-suspended payload in heptagonal formation. No drone knows the team size or other agents' states.

02



02 Cable snap
At t = 7 s, cable 1 snaps. The freed drone accelerates away. Remaining drones get a sudden 17% load-share increase.

03



03 Stable recovery
After 3 cascading snaps (t = 7, 12, 14 s), 4 surviving drones keep tracking with bounded error (43.6 cm RMSE).

2 Why the system stays stable

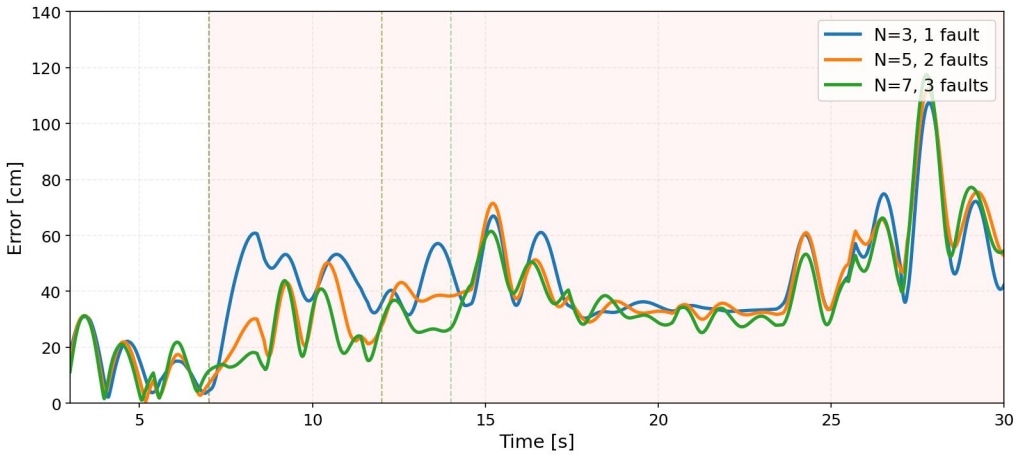
Topology-invariant error dynamics

Cable snaps change the disturbance input d_i(t), but not the closed-loop matrices (A, B). The error dynamics remain stable across all cable topologies.

$$\dot{z} = A z + B d_i(t)$$

- **Proposition 1**
  A, B depend only on PID gains (kp, kd, ki) — independent of N, payload mass, or cable topology.
- **Common Lyapunov**
  A single Lyapunov function works across all cable topologies — no switching needed.
- **Design tools**
  Cost ratio: $\rho_{FT} = N/(N-k)$.
  Thrust margin: $f_{max} > (N m_Q + m_L) g/(N-k) + f_{track}$.
- **Oracle comparison**
  A centralized controller with perfect fault knowledge improves RMSE by only 0.7%.

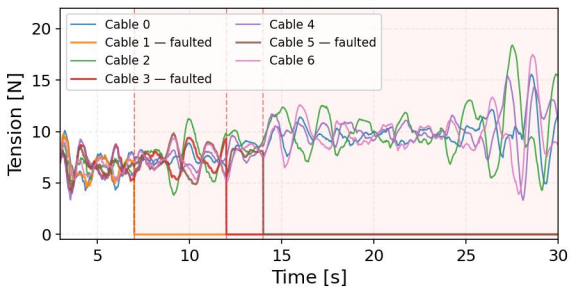
Tracking error stays bounded after each fault



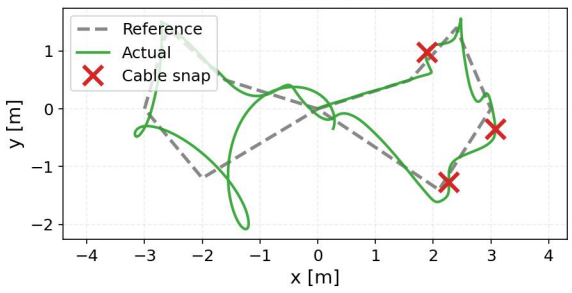
<3% MC variation | 0.7% oracle gain

3 Evidence from the multibody simulations

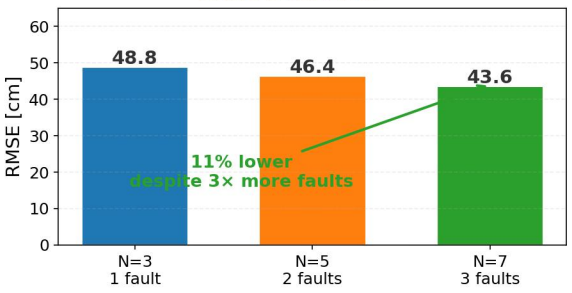
Cable tensions redistribute after each snap



Payload path remains close to the reference



Larger teams dilute each fault's impact



Key takeaway: a local N-agnostic PID + gravity-feedforward controller can tolerate cascading cable snaps without communication or explicit fault detection.